

Assignment 1

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Bad Interface Example: WC in LX Factory, Lisbon



The picture on the left shows a WC at LX Factory: a vibrant cultural complex in Lisbon set in a former industrial area, featuring restaurants, shops, art galleries, and creative spaces.

To match the design and style of the surrounding area, the toilets are decorated with vibrant and unexpected colors and feature exposed pipes that reveal valves, gauges, and other mechanical components, as seen in the image. However, while this design is aesthetically striking, it is not user-friendly. Users might struggle to locate the flush button, as it is the same color as the pipes and does not stand out (indicated by the red arrow in the photo). They might even attempt to turn the more visible and eye-catching blue handle nearby (indicated by the blue arrow).

When I was there, I personally encountered this issue: turning the blue handle slightly has no effect and is therefore not dangerous, but it remains confusing and unintuitive. Since it apparently has no real function and serves only an aesthetic purpose, it should be removed.

Moreover, toilets should maintain high hygiene standards, and all these unnecessary exposed pipes could pose a safety hazard. It is clear that the intention was to create an eclectic and visually interesting space. I would suggest keeping the vibrant colors and perhaps playing with lighting to maintain this atmosphere. However, the current flush design is not functional, and it would be better to replace it with a more traditional, larger, and more visible flush mechanism; without the exposed pipes and valves.

Good Interface Example: Lisbon Public Transport Ticket Vending Machines



In the picture, the interface shown is a ticket vending machine commonly found in Lisbon. On the left, we see the machine itself, while the bottom right corner displays a zoomed-in view of the touchscreen (connected with a green arrow) and the top right shows the payment and card-reloading area (connected with a red arrow). The goal of this interface is to allow users to purchase tickets and reload transport cards quickly and efficiently.

The touchscreen guides users step by step, supported by clear visuals and simple text. Language selection is highly intuitive: users can choose a language by tapping on a flag instead of reading text, making the machine more accessible to tourists.

The interface also communicates effectively through visual cues indicating where to insert cash, a payment card, or a transport card. Pictures of the compatible transport cards are placed directly next to the slot where they must be inserted, helping users distinguish between the card-reload slot and the payment-card slot.

The machine provides clear feedback, such as on-screen confirmation messages and printed receipts, reassuring the user throughout the process.

It also includes Braille, further enhancing accessibility. Additionally, the machine is easy to locate thanks to its prominent “Bilhetes e passes” sign, and accepted payment methods are clearly indicated both on the machine and on the screen. Overall, this interface combines strong visual communication, accessibility features, and clear guidance to create a user-friendly public service tool.